

GREECE AND BULGARIA



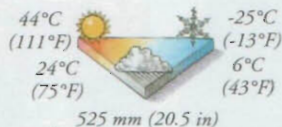
ALTHOUGH Greece and Bulgaria share a border, high mountains separate the two countries, making communication difficult. Greece and Bulgaria are quite different. Three-fifths of the Greek mainland is mountainous, and only one-third of the land is cultivated. By contrast, Bulgaria is much more fertile with a strong agricultural tradition. Greece has a strong history of democratic government, while Bulgaria is only just emerging from almost half a century of communist rule.

Physical features

Surrounded by sea on three sides, the country of Greece is made up of the mainland, the Peloponnese peninsula, and more than 2,000 islands. It is a mixture of high mountains, dry, dusty plains, and dramatic coastlines. Landlocked on three sides, Bulgaria has broad fertile valleys, separated by the Balkan and Rhodope mountains.

Regional climate

Greece has very hot, dry summers and cooler winters. The northern mountains have cold winters. Annual rainfall is low, and the country suffers from water shortages. Bulgaria, by contrast, has warm summers and cold, snowy winters, with a high rainfall – especially in the mountains.



Danubian Plain

The mighty River Danube forms most of Bulgaria's northern border with Romania, flowing through the vast and fertile Danubian Plain that extends across the width of the country. This rolling farmland is used for grazing sheep, goats, and cattle, and for cultivating a variety of crops including sunflowers, which are grown for their oil.



Crete

The largest of the Greek islands at 8,380 sq km (3,235 sq miles), Crete lies 100 km (62 miles) southeast of the Greek mainland. More than 600,000 people live on the island, and one third of Cretans are farmers. Many people work in tourism.



Mount Olympus

Much of central and western Greece is made up of steep, rugged mountains, many of which are capped with snow for several months of the year. Mount Olympus is Greece's highest peak at 2,917 m (9,570 ft). Once thought to be the home of the gods, it is now a national park with busy ski resorts.



Orthodox Church

Greece is the only official Christian Orthodox country in the world. Priests are responsible community figures and play an important part in national events. Most Greeks and Bulgars belong to the Eastern Orthodox Church, which split from the Roman Catholic Church in 1054.



Each country has its own branch of the Church, which also flourishes in other parts of eastern Europe, and Russia. Around one tenth of the world's Christians belong to the Orthodox Church.

Greek Orthodox priest

